

Phish Lab



BIG IDEA Fake messages work by rushing and flattering you. A calm check with the FLAGS list turns “click” into “pause.”

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: R3 packet per group (10 DM cards: 6 fake, 3 real, 1 “not sure”), a FLAGS bookmark per student, highlighters. No real links in class.

- ☐ Print one packet per group and a FLAGS bookmark per student.
- ☐ Keep the Teacher Answer Key at hand.
- ☐ Everything in the packets is made up.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Hackles up? Prizes, deadlines and requests for passwords are classic hackle-raisers. A false alarm is fine. “Here is a message: ‘Your account will be closed in 30 minutes unless you verify now. Tap the link.’ (Pause.) What does it want me to do, and how fast? Notice ‘now.’ Fake messages need you to act before you think, so slowing down is a strong defense. Today you analyze messages and click nothing. Anyone, adults and experts included, has been fooled at some point. If you ever click one, it is never your fault, and there is a clear next step.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Phish Lab*

- 1 (1 min) FLAGS.** **F** Fast. **L** Login ask. **A** Amazing offer. **G** Gotta keep it secret. **S** Strange sender or link. One flag is a warning; two or more is a reason to stop. Rush, worry or excitement is a cue to pause too.
- 2 (5 min) Lab time in groups.** For each of ten DM cards, circle the flags, sort into Fake, Real or Not sure (ask an adult), and write the first move for each fake: do not reply, do not click, report, delete, tell. Some messages are real. The goal is to check, with no need to distrust everything.
- 3 (2 min) Debrief.** Each group shares one fake that surprised them. “Not sure” is a correct answer: open the app yourself, never the link. Already clicked? Tell an adult, change the password, turn on 2-step verification.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Which flag showed up most? Which was hardest to notice?”
- 2** “What is the safest way to check an account message?” (Open the app or site yourself.)
- 3** “Why is ‘Not sure’ a strong choice?”

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause before you click. Check with FLAGS. Tell an adult when you are not sure. If you did click, it is never your fault. Tell someone and fix it.”

Hand signal: Hackles Up (hand brushed up the neck, optional), then Pause, Check, Tell. Post it: “The rush is the trick. Slow is a superpower.”

EXIT TICKET “A message says: ‘Verify your account in 10 minutes or lose your game.’ Write two FLAGS letters you see and what you will do first.”

FUN BOOST Slow-Down Scoring. Groups earn points for the best first move on a card, never for speed, because speed is what a scammer wants.

LEVEL-UP Flag Spotter Week. Notice flags in ads, pop-ups and texts without clicking or sharing. Bring only a described example, never a screenshot.

DIFFERENTIATE Use six cards (4 fake, 2 real) with one flag pre-circled and DMs read aloud.

FAMILY CARD Show each other a made-up or old fake message and name the flags. Nobody gets in trouble for clicking and telling you right away.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.”
- “This is not your fault, and you are not in trouble.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help, and I will tell you who.”
- **Do not say:** “Are you sure?” or “How could you fall for that?”
- “I won’t tell anyone.”
- Asking to see messages, photos or accounts.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.